

Oscar Niemeyer

Oscar Niemeyer (1907–2012) became a pioneer of modernist architecture, introducing it to his home country of Brazil from the 1940s onwards, and was the first modernist from a country beyond Europe or North America to achieve global fame. Niemeyer often used large expanses of glass and curvilinear forms, but in contrast with the Germanic 'glass box' of modernism, his buildings were expressive and sinuous. His designs for the new capital city, Brasília, were noted for their free-flowing lines (opposite). Niemeyer's early works show Le Corbusier's influence, but he gradually formulated his own style, and specialized in light, rounded forms that create a sense of harmony and elegance. He explored the aesthetic possibilities of reinforced concrete in skyscrapers, exhibition centres, residential areas, theatres, offices, universities and hospitals; the Itamaraty Palace (1962–70) in Brasília, for instance, features rough concrete arches that appear to float on the surrounding pool, and a seemingly unsupported cascade of spiralling stairs in the atrium.

